young people take down this Wall, bit by bit. … Tonight, citizens from both Germanys are singing and dancing on the wall itself." Brokaw's on-scene reporting included elaborate references to the sounds and sights of the breached border, in which the politics and culture of the city mirrored each other. "Tonight, in this city, famous for its carefree nightlife," Brokaw added, "in this city where the song says, 'Life is a cabaret,' tonight in Berlin it's freedom night."[9] Noting that some celebrants were either too inebriated to participate in the collective gathering or had been escorted away by existing border control, Brokaw stated that as *Mauerpeckers* (wall peckers) began chiseling away chunks that night, East German border guards began clearing passages and new openings, thus participating in a new era that would render their own jobs obsolete.

That night and in the weeks that followed, the border was transformed into a stage for fantasies of political and cultural experimentation. The German term *Wende*, or turning point, refers to both the time period and the cultural shock of this historic change. (The Wende Museum, based in Los Angeles, was founded in 2002 by Justinan Jampol as a repository of historically relevant but discarded material culture from the former Eastern bloc.) The term also conjures the ambivalence of the moment for many Germans, torn between profound joy for outliving the border system and the unhinging, if not loss, of their respective ways of life. Freedom was one of the buzzwords of the moment, but the practice and follow-through of what the term "freedom" entailed would remain elusive among the newest of German ruins.[10]

From 1989 forward, returning and new cohorts of American Berliners—some of whom then resided in Berlin during the Cold War, while others were well versed in the American folklore of the city upon arrival—continued to treat the Berlin Wall as a central site and symbol of the U.S. cultural imagination, despite its disappearance as a formidable border and the subsequent reunification of Germany.[11] Over the next years, foreign visitors carried a wave of Wall fragments away from Berlin, with several larger concrete panels en route to new displays in American public spaces, national museums, presidential libraries, universities, and other sites of memory. Global politicians celebrated a new age of idealized borderlessness, on one hand, while building new walls of separation, on the other. As they had